

# 17 Fleet Street and Prince Henry's Room

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Number 17 Fleet Street is one of the few buildings in the City of London to survive the Great Fire in 1666. It has a large room with fine wooden panelling and an intricate plaster ceiling on the first floor.

From the middle of the 12th century, the whole area between Fleet Street and the Thames was home to the Knights Templar, when they were moved from their original base in Holborn. In 1185 their Round Church was dedicated. The order continued in possession until it was abolished by the Council of Vienna in 1312.

The property then passed to the Knights Hospitallers of the Order of St. John of Jerusalem, who granted a lease for a yearly rental to students of the law. Lawyers remain there to this day. The frontage to Fleet Street was not included in this lease. It was occupied by the offices of the Order, and included an Inn, probably called “the hande”, which was leased to Robert Bray in 1515. The records continue, and in 1598, John Bennett succeeded his father as the tenant. In 1609 John Bennett received a Royal grant of the office of sergeant-at-arms. In 1610 he decided to rebuild. There is a detailed agreement with the Inner Temple “to rebuild his house, called the Prince’s Arms, adjoining to, and over, the Inner Temple Gate, and may jettie over the said gate”. In 1544, William Blake became the new owner, and his alehouse, the Prince’s Arms, extended over the gateway. After further sales, the premises were sold in 1671 to James Sotheby, whose family continued to own it until 1900.

In 1544 the front part of the house was taken by Mrs Clark, who for some time ran a business called Mrs Salmon’s Waxworks. The Morning Post carried a report: “...the figures are moved to the very spacious and



handsome apartments... which were once the Palace of Henry, Prince of Wales...and they are now the residence of many a royal guest...Alexander the Great, King Henry VIII, Caracacus, and the present Duke of York”. The waxworks continued here until about 1816.

The attribution of the room to Henry, Prince of Wales, is not firmly established. It could have been an upper room of the inn, the Prince’s Arms, though the quality of the ceiling and panelling suggests a more important use. It may have been connected to the Duchy of Cornwall, which Henry received when made

Prince of Wales in 1610. The Prince died in 1612, so his association with this room was brief.

The London County Council became interested in the site in 1895 when the owner planned to demolish it. The Council decided to acquire and restore the building. With support from the City Corporation, it was bought in 1900 and opened to the public in 1906.

The building then consisted of a four-storey front block over Inner Temple Lane and a modern rear block, linked by a wooden staircase. A false timber and glass front hid the older building. Behind it, the original early 1600s half-timbered front was discovered, damaged but still intact.

The main feature is the Jacobean plaster ceiling, decorated with the Prince of Wales feathers. It had suffered from paint, whitewash, and sagging timbers. The stained glass windows are modern, donated by CY Sturge, showing arms of Prince Henry and the London County Council.

In 1969, the site passed to the City of London Corporation. It is not usually open to the public.